them fight.

The boy wasn't just acquiring new pets in Hindustan, but also new prey. On the very day that Humayun entered Delhi, news arrived that Akbar had killed a nilgai with the strength of his own sword. Impressed, Humayun ordered some of its flesh preserved – he had sworn off meat for Ramzan, a vow to aid his conquest of Hindustan, but would keep this for when his fast was over.[3] It was also in Punjab, around the time of that nilgai's demise, that Akbar began to learn how to shoot; he would acquire an almost legendary skill with the musket.

None of this was either surprising or unusual; a prince must know how to kill.[4] Akbar's role in Humayun's return to Hindustan wasn't only to see the sights and acquire a menagerie, he was expected to participate in its conquest. Thus, for that great forty-day battle for Sirhind, the prince was given command of a battalion. Historians are coy about what the boy did, exactly, with his troops. Even Abul Fazl only describes Akbar standing on a rooftop, watching the vast spread of a 'hostile army' in the distance, and uttering one of his prophecies: 'that in a short time "our" men would disperse it'.

It is not surprising or shameful that Akbar wasn't on the front lines at Sirhind. Hunting animals is not the same as killing men, and it would be a while before Akbar was able to bring himself to shed human blood. He was only thirteen years old, after all.

And now, with a sudden thunder of galloping hooves at his camp, and urgent confabulations in Bairam's tent, Akbar was also king.[5]

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He was crowned upon a throne of brick in Kalanaur, today a small tahsil in Punjab, just this side of India's border with Pakistan. Decades later, the most acerbic historian of Akbar's reign, Abdul Qadir Badauni, would write of how, 'to this day, they have not yet finished laying out' the gardens around the throne.[6] If those gardens were ever laid, they have long disappeared. The 'throne' – a bare seat of plastered brick on a discoloured platform – stands as unadorned as it must have been when Akbar sat upon it.[7]

Akbar was unadorned, too, save a black crown and a golden robe. In